

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

8 February 2012

To an individual Bahá'í

Dear Bahá'í Friend,

Your email letter of 26 September 2011 regarding the time at which the Tablet of Visitation is to be recited during programs held to commemorate the Ascension of Bahá'u'lláh has been received by the Universal House of Justice. We have been asked to respond as follows.

As you know, the Bahá'í day starts and ends at sunset. While on some of the anniversaries the believers may gather at any time during the day they find convenient, the Guardian has advised that, if feasible, the friends should commemorate certain Holy Days at the following times:

The Declaration of the Báb at about 2 hours after sunset.

The First Day of Riḍván at about 3:00 p.m.

The Martyrdom of the Báb at about noon.

The Ascension of Bahá'u'lláh at 3:00 a.m.

The Ascension of 'Abdu'l-Bahá at 1:00 a.m.

The House of Justice has further clarified that the observance of those Holy Days for which particular times are specified, as indicated above, is to take place at local standard time, rather than daylight saving time. In accordance with this schedule, the observances held on each Holy Day succeed one another for an entire twenty-four hours, as the earth turns on its axis. If two neighboring communities in different time zones wish to hold a joint meeting, they would, presumably, use the standard time of the zone in which they meet. In high latitudes, where there are extremes of daylight and darkness, it is permissible to go by the clock.

Nothing has been found in the Writings to indicate that reciting the Tablets of Visitation is mandatory at commemorations of the anniversaries associated with the Central Figures of the Faith, nor has any Text been found concerning the timing of the recitation of these Tablets during Holy Day observances. Although, as an act of reverence, the friends generally stand and face the Sacred Threshold when reciting the Tablet of Visitation in, or within the precincts of, one of the Holy Shrines, nothing has been found in the Writings requiring the friends to stand and face the Qiblih whenever the Tablets of Visitation are read on other occasions. All questions concerning such secondary matters are left to the discretion of the relevant National and Local Spiritual Assemblies, which are entrusted with the responsibility of ensuring that Holy Day observances are conducted in the proper spirit. The friends should safeguard the unity of the community and not allow any of these points to become a cause of argument and disagreement. Certainly no issue should be made about such matters while a Holy Day program is being held.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]